The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter

Photograph: AFP

Iran and **America** scrambled to find the pilot of an American F-15 fighter plane that was shot down over southern Iran. Reuters reported that two American Blackhawk helicopters involved in the search were struck by Iranian fire, but escaped the scene. Were Iran to capture the airman alive, it could trigger another round of military escalation by Donald Trump. Iran also reportedly downed an A-10 Warthog aircraft near the Strait of Hormuz. Its pilot was rescued safely.

America's economy added 178,000 jobs in March, much more than expected. The Bureau of Labour Statistics also revised down February's figure from a loss of 92,000 to one of 133,000, underscoring recent volatility in the jobs market. Traders now expect the Federal Reserve to leave interest rates unchanged this year as it assesses the effects of the Iran war on inflation.

The Trump administration said it would ask for a significant rise in **defence spending** in its **budget request** to Congress for the 2027 fiscal year. The request includes $1.5trn in military funding, a rise of more than 40% compared with the previous year. The administration said it would partly offset the increase with cuts of $73bn to non-military spending.

Israel struck Beirut, **Lebanon's** capital. The Israel Defence Forces hit what they said were Hizbullah-linked sites in the city's southern suburbs, after ordering evacuations in several neighbourhoods. The strikes come as Israel presses on with its offensive in southern Lebanon. Meanwhile America urged its citizens to leave Lebanon, warning that Iran may target American-linked universities.

Volodymyr Zelensky said that **Ukraine's** position on its frontline with Russia was the most positive in almost a year. The Institute of War, a think-tank, and a British intelligence report both suggested that Russia had made next-to-no gains over the past ten months. Massive Russian airstrikes continued across Ukraine, however. Mr Zelensky concluded the Kremlin had refused his offer of an Easter ceasefire.

Cuba began releasing prisoners after announcing an amnesty for more than 2,000 inmates, the biggest in a decade. Those freed were reportedly mostly people jailed for ordinary crimes. Whether political prisoners will be included—a key issue in talks with America—remains unclear; the Trump administration said it is closely monitoring who is released.

Officials said public transport would be made free for a month in Islamabad, **Pakistan's** capital, and Punjab, the country's most populous state. The move came in response to protests against the government's hiking of fuel prices throughout the country. As in much of Asia, energy imports have become scarce because of the war in Iran.

Word of the week: "workslop", the unnecessary AI-generated slop that is produced when bosses tell employees they must use the technology. Read Ethan Mollick's guest essay on why employers should treat AI as what it is: weird.

Correction: *In "The LNG and short of it" (published in our April 2nd edition) we incorrectly stated that QatarEnergy had cancelled,*

rather than suspended, contracts with its four largest customers, rather than with four of its largest customers. The photo accompanying the article was also not of an LNG *ship. Sorry.*

Photograph: Getty Images

Vietnam’s leader tightens his grip on power

Vietnam’s leaders will gather this weekend ahead of the country’s National Assembly on Monday. Top of the agenda will be the election of new national leaders. To Lam, the chief of the Communist Party, is widely expected to be named president. That would mark a break with precedent: unlike in China, Vietnam has traditionally kept the leadership of party and state separate.

Mr Lam, a former policeman, became general secretary after his predecessor died in 2024. Since then he has pushed through sweeping bureaucratic reforms, cutting the number of provinces and shedding tens of thousands of state employees. In January he won out in a factional battle with the army to secure a full five-year term as the party’s general secretary. Taking on the presidency would further concentrate power in his hands, moving Vietnam away from its traditionally more collective style of leadership—and closer to the model seen in China.

Photograph: Dasarath Deka/ZUMA/eyevine

Iran war looms over India’s state elections

Narendra Modi, India’s prime minister, will visit Kerala this weekend to campaign ahead of state elections next Thursday. The contest is set to challenge the truism that “all politics is local”. In Assam and Puducherry, campaigns still revolve around familiar domestic concerns.

In Kerala, however, the war with Iran looms large. Around 80% of the state’s more than 2m emigrants live in the Gulf, and the region accounts for roughly 40% of India’s remittances. That leaves Keralites unusually exposed to the conflict’s risks. The incumbent communist-led government has criticised Mr Modi’s reluctance to publicly condemn the Western-led attacks, tapping into the state’s long-standing anti-imperialist sentiment.

The prime minister’s Bharatiya Janata Party is also trying to turn the crisis to its advantage. It points to the evacuation of tens of thousands of Indian citizens and Mr Modi’s ties with Gulf monarchs, betting that, in a crisis, voters will prioritise safety and effective diplomacy over ideological opposition to the war.

Photograph: Alamy

Britain’s boat race enters new waters

The Oxford and Cambridge Boat Race has not changed much in its 197 years. The decidedly British affair sees university rowers race along the Thames as some 250,000 spectators link the banks. There will be Pimms, picnics and poshos aplenty.

Britons love the familiarity of the fanfare. So some will be unhappy to discover a change to this year’s race, which takes place on Saturday. The BBC has broadcast it almost continuously since 1938 (aside from a stint on ITV between 2005 and 2009). Last year 2.8m people tuned in. But in October Channel 4 won the television rights; the BBC lost the radio rights earlier this year, too.

Critics see that as evidence that the public-service broadcaster is losing its way, neglecting beloved British traditions for more contemporary programming, such as game shows. Some may conclude that the boat crews are not the only ones in danger of being left behind.

Photograph: Alamy

Weekend profile: Mohamed Bagher Qalibaf, Iran’s potential dealmaker

For decades, Mohamed Bagher Qalibaf has tried to make himself the people’s choice. Over more than 20 years he has run for president repeatedly and each time voters have chosen someone else. What the ballot box denied him, however, war may yet supply. A wave of Israeli assassinations has thinned Iran’s senior ranks, placing the wily 64-year-old at the centre of decision-making.

Among the regime’s ageing elite, Mr Qalibaf stands out. A product of the Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps (IRGC), he has often leaned towards pragmatism: diplomacy over confrontation, deals over dogma. When Donald Trump mused about new Iranian interlocutors willing to negotiate, he may have had figures like Mr Qalibaf in mind.

His military credentials are formidable. He fought in the Iran–Iraq war of the 1980s, forging ties with commanders who remain influential. A rapid riser, he was appointed head of the IRGC’s air force in his mid-30s. On a recent visit to Beirut to meet Hizbullah, an Iran-backed militant group, he reportedly piloted his own aircraft. When the Islamic Republic shifted from war to reconstruction in the 1990s, he pivoted to politics. He served for 12 years as mayor of Tehran, the capital, and, since 2020, as speaker of parliament.

He has never been especially popular. He once boasted of charging anti-regime protesters on a motorbike, a remark that has stuck. But he has long enjoyed the backing of powerful insiders, including Mojtaba Khamenei, the new supreme leader (and son of the last one), and Hossein Taeb, a former intelligence chief.

That backing has not shielded him from criticism among regime insiders. Hardliners accuse him of profiteering. As mayor, he was linked to the transfer of valuable public land to Guard-related entities and to a charity run by his wife. Social media has amplified stories of family wealth, including a failed attempt by his son to secure a Canadian passport.

For ideologues who cast the Islamic Republic as a champion of the poor, such tales jar. Yet those same traits that made him unpopular —pragmatism, connections and a tolerance for dealmaking—may now work in his favour.

For the moment, Mr Qalibaf is keeping a low profile. The bombastic video messages he posted early in the conflict have given way to terse social-media posts. Some speculate that he is injured or dead. Younger hardliners are gaining ground, and Israel has shown a readiness to target potential dealmakers. In war, as in politics, his moment may yet slip away.

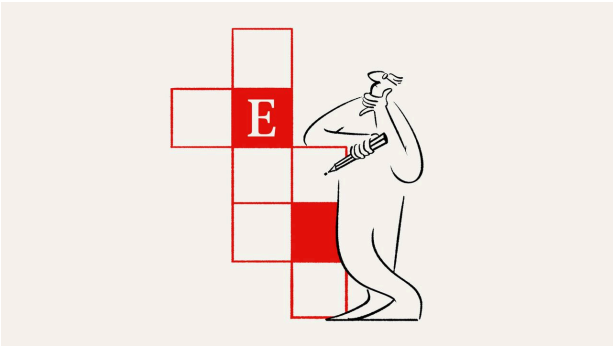

Illustration: The Economist

Mini crossword

We publish a new interactive edition of our crossword daily, allowing you to enter and check the answers and see explanations. Try it here. Or, if you prefer, use the clues below.

There are two sets of clues, one for seasoned cruciverbalists and the other for less experienced solvers. Both give the same answers.

Cryptic clues

1 across - One who rests makes tracks (7)

2 across - Too many don’t go back to find ball of energy (6)

3 across - Statesman’s frightful treason (7)

1 down - No! SOS! Children throw up what they have to eat between lessons (6,7)

Straight clues

1 across - Something that achieves delayed success (7)

2 across - Changes movement into electricity (6)

3 across - Schumer, for example (7)

4 down - Institutional meals (6,7)

Illustration: Sandra Navarro

The winners of this week's quiz

Thank you to everyone who took part in this week's quiz. The winners, chosen at random, were:

Nancy Dixon, Kansas City, Missouri, America
Iskriyana Vasileva, Berlin, Germany
Dervla Batt, Dublin, Ireland

They gave the correct answers of John Stennis, George H.W. Bush, Harry Truman, Chester Nimitz and Gerald Ford. The theme is that they all have current US aircraft carriers named after them.

The questions were

Monday: Richard Nixon proposed which long-running Mississippi Senator, who suffered from poor healing, as an intermediary who should listen to the Watergate tapes and summarise them for investigators?

Tuesday: Who served as both America's ambassador to the United Nations and director of the CIA in the 1970s?

Wednesday: Who was the only American president to be born in Missouri?

Thursday: Which Admiral was selected to be commander of the US Pacific fleet in the wake of the Pearl Harbour attacks?

Friday: Which American president pardoned Richard Nixon?

Hell is truth seen too late.

Thomas Hobbes